

Social Security Credits [\(En español\)](#)

You must earn at least 40 Social Security credits to be eligible for Social Security benefits. You earn credits when you work and pay Social Security taxes.

The number of credits does not affect the amount of benefits you receive. We use the number of credits you've earned to determine your eligibility for retirement or disability benefits, Medicare, and your family's eligibility for survivors benefits.

We cannot pay benefits to you if you don't have enough credits.

How Credits Are Earned

Since 1978, you can earn up to a maximum of four credits per year.

Credits are based on your total wages and self-employment income for the year. You might work all year to earn four credits, or you might earn enough for all four in less time.

The amount of earnings it takes to earn a credit may change each year. In 2026, you earn one Social Security and Medicare credit for every \$1,890 in covered earnings each year. You must earn \$7,560 to get the maximum four credits for the year.

During your lifetime, you might earn more credits than the minimum number you need to be eligible for benefits. These extra credits do not increase your benefit amount. The average of your earnings over your working years, not the total number of credits you earn, determines how much your monthly payment will be when you receive benefits.

Read our publication, "[How You Earn Credits](#)," for more information.

Number of Credits Needed for Retirement Benefits

You need 40 credits to be eligible for retirement.

Number of Credits Needed for Disability Benefits

To be eligible for disability benefits, you must meet a **recent work test** and a **duration work test**.

The number of credits necessary to meet the recent work test depends on the age you become disabled. The rules are as follows:

- **Before age 24** - You may be eligible if you have six credits earned in the three-year period ending when your disability starts.
- **Age 24 to 31** – In general, you may be eligible if you have credit for working half the time between age 21 and the time your disability began. As an example, if you develop a disability at age 27, you will need three years of work (12 credits) out of the past six years (between ages 21 and 27).
- **Age 31 or older** - In general, you must have at least 20 credits in the 10-year period immediately before your disability began.

The following table shows how many years of work credits you need to meet the duration of work test based on your age when your disability began. For the duration of work test, your work does not have to fall within a certain period of time. The table only provides an estimate of how many work credits you need. It does not cover all situations. If you are statutorily blind, you must only meet the duration of work test. When statutory blindness is involved, there is not a recent work test requirement.

NOTE: *This table is an estimate only and does not cover all situations.*

If you develop a disability at...	Then you generally need:
Before age 28	1.5 years of work
Age 30	2 years
Age 34	3 years
Age 38	4 years
Age 42	5 years
Age 44	5.5 years
Age 46	6 years
Age 48	6.5 years
Age 50	7 years
Age 52	7.5 years
Age 54	8 years
Age 56	8.5 years
Age 58	9 years
Age 60	9.5 years

Number of Credits Needed for Survivors Benefits

The number of credits needed for family members to be eligible for survivors benefits depends on your age when you die. The younger you are, the fewer credits needed. Nobody needs more than 40 credits.

Under a special rule, we can pay benefits to your children and your spouse caring for your children,

even if your record doesn't have the number of credits needed. They can get benefits if you have credits for one and half year's work (six credits) in the three years before your death.

If you are receiving retirement or disability benefits at the time of your death, we will pay your survivors based on that entitlement. We will not have to determine your credits again.